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INKLINGS

COFFEE & TEA



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I. Executive Summary

What is Inklings Coffee and Tea?

Inklings Coffee and Tea is an innovative and inviting coffeehouse poised to become a staple in the local community. With a passion for creating a warm and inspiring atmosphere, Inklings aims to be more than just a coffee destination; it aspires to be a hub for creativity, collaboration, and meaningful connections.

Mission Statement

At Inklings, our mission is to provide a haven where people can gather, unwind, and engage in intellectual and creative pursuits while savoring exceptional coffee and delectable treats. We are committed to fostering an environment that encourages dialogue, inspiration, and the exchange of ideas.

Unique Selling Proposition (USP)

What sets Inklings apart is our commitment to merging the world of literature and coffee culture. The café boasts a curated selection of books, a cozy reading nook, and literary-themed events, creating a distinctive and immersive experience for our patrons. This unique fusion of culture and community sets Inklings apart in a crowded market.



I. Executive Summary continued ...



Key Features:

1. **Exceptional Coffee:** Inklings is dedicated to serving high-quality, ethically sourced coffee beans, expertly brewed by our skilled baristas.
2. **Literary Atmosphere:** A thoughtfully designed space with bookshelves, cozy reading corners, and literary-inspired décor to promote a contemplative and inspiring ambiance.
3. **Community Engagement:** Regular events such as book clubs, author meet-ups, and open mic nights create a sense of community and intellectual exchange.
4. **Culinary Delights:** Inklings offers a diverse menu of artisanal pastries, sandwiches, and desserts, ensuring a delightful culinary experience for our customers.

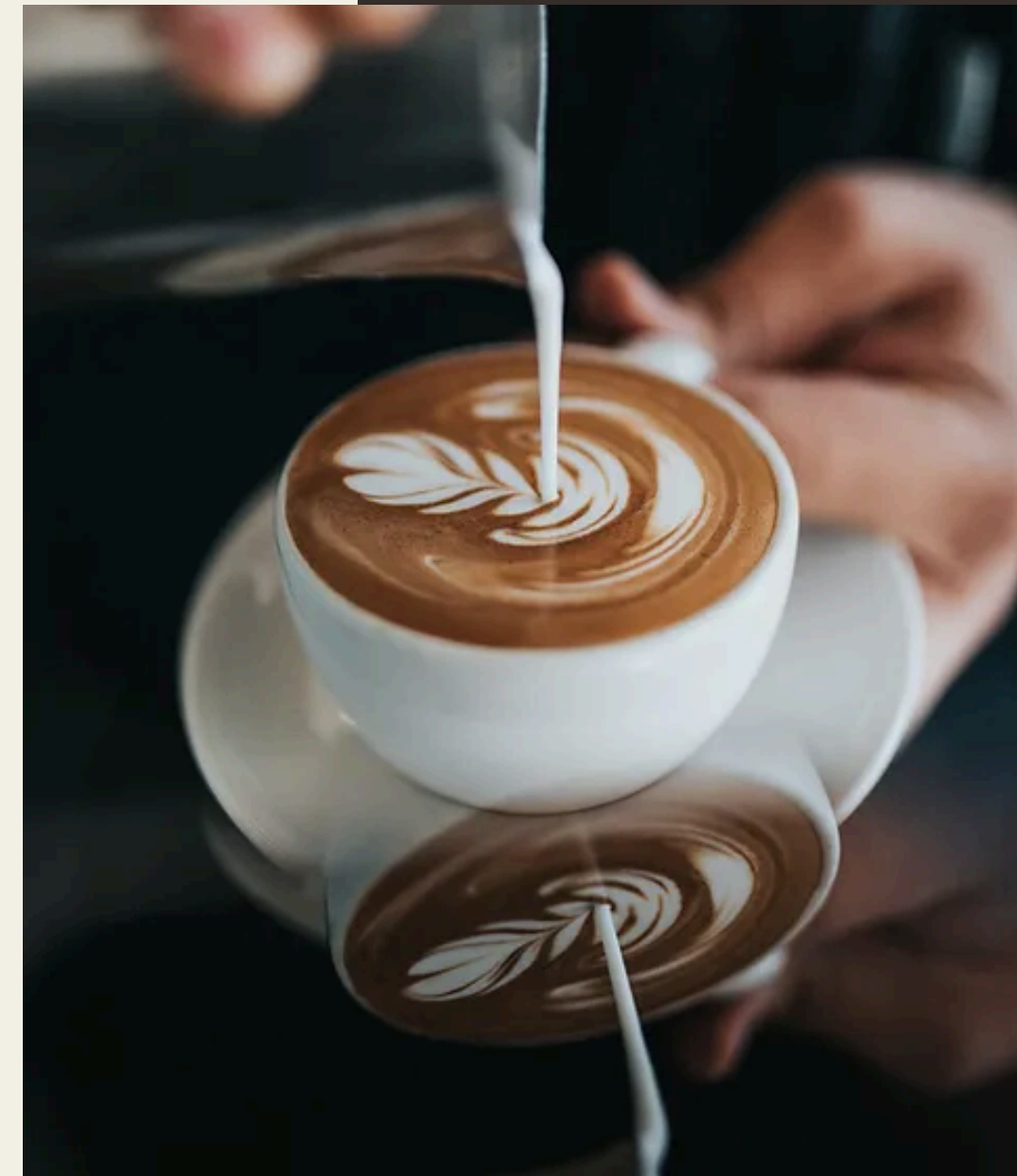
Future Expansion:

With a solid foundation, Inklings aims to expand its footprint by exploring franchise opportunities and additional locations. The brand's commitment to fostering creativity and community will remain central as we continue to grow. Inklings Café is not just a place to enjoy a cup of coffee; it's a destination for those who seek inspiration, connection, and a sense of community. Join us on this journey where every sip tells a story and every moment is an opportunity to create something extraordinary.

II. Introduction

A.

Inklings, situated in the vibrant heart of Pleasanton Downtown, is not just a cafe; it's a welcoming haven that embodies warmth and community. With a commitment to excellence, Inklings prioritizes the use of high-quality ingredients in crafting its products. The cozy ambiance, adorned with a charming wooden interior, creates an atmosphere that feels like home. As you step inside, the inviting decor and friendly staff immediately make you feel part of a thriving community. Whether you're sipping on a meticulously brewed cup of coffee or indulging in their delectable treats, Inklings goes beyond being a cafe—it's a cherished gathering place that prioritizes both exceptional culinary experiences and the forging of lasting connections within the community.



CARAMEL BURBON LATTE

II. Introduction

B.

Inklings caters specifically to the growing demographic of young professionals and creatives in Pleasanton, seeking a respite from the virtual workspaces and on-demand entertainment that define the fast-paced culture of today. This target audience, aged 25 to 35, values authentic connections and a sense of community in their lives. Inklings becomes a sanctuary for these individuals, providing a cozy and welcoming environment where they can break away from screens, engage in genuine conversations, and relish the delight of quality coffee and artisanal treats. By understanding the unique needs of this specific demographic, Inklings becomes not just a cafe but a personalized space that addresses the desires of those craving authentic connections amidst the demands of modern-day living. Inklings is also a home for families and young children, given its young and inviting atmosphere that gives you the feeling of being at your childhood home.



Nitro Cold Brew w/ Foam

II. Introduction

c.

Inklings has crafted a comprehensive approach to its employee lifecycle, beginning with a recruitment strategy that leverages both its online platform and the power of employee referrals. The online application process, coupled with referrals, allows for a diverse talent pool while prioritizing insights from current or former staff. The hiring process is characterized by follow-up interviews, emphasizing the cafe's commitment to evaluating not just skills but also cultural alignment within Inklings' warm and community-oriented environment. Onboarding, a crucial phase in the employee journey, is personalized to integrate new hires seamlessly into the cafe's unique atmosphere, emphasizing the cozy wooden interior and the commitment to high-quality ingredients. However, the true strength lies in Inklings' proactive retention strategies. Frequent pay raises showcase a dedication to recognizing and rewarding employee contributions, fostering job satisfaction, while benefits like product discounts for friends and family contribute to a positive workplace culture. Inklings' approach, from recruitment to retention, reflects a holistic commitment to creating not only a workplace that attracts top talent but also a supportive and rewarding environment that nurtures and values its employees throughout their tenure.



Lavendar Latte

III. Research Methods

In our dedicated effort to enhance employee retention at Inklings, we initiated an in-depth analysis of the business. This comprehensive examination aimed to pinpoint existing challenges and areas of improvement within our current employee retention strategies. By delving into various aspects of our operations, work culture, and employee feedback, we identified specific pain points that may contribute to turnover. This thorough evaluation laid the groundwork for devising effective solutions tailored to address these challenges.

To gauge the effectiveness of potential solutions, we strategically designed a survey with targeted questions. Some questions were crafted as forced-choice, requiring respondents to select from predetermined options. This approach allows for structured insights into preferred solutions and provides quantitative data that can guide decision-making. Additionally, we incorporated open-ended questions to encourage employees to share specific experiences, suggestions, and concerns. These qualitative responses offer a more nuanced understanding of the issues at hand, providing valuable context to complement the quantitative data.

The synergy between forced-choice and open-ended questions ensures a well-rounded survey approach. It enables us to obtain both specific, conclusive data on preferred solutions and nuanced, qualitative insights that capture the intricacies of employee experiences. This methodological combination positions us to not only identify the most favored solutions from an employee's perspective but also to understand the underlying sentiments and perspectives that influence their choices.



Survey URL



III. Research Methods continued...



Survey

For our research method we decided to conduct a survey. To create the survey we used Google Surveys because of its very user-friendly interface, which could mitigate the risk of not being able to understand how to use the survey, especially for employees who may not be good at using tech.

In Person Questions

We talked to real life employees that are currently employed at Inklings about there experiences working for the company and why or why not they liked working there. This may have not been definite data but it allowed us to get a broader undertstanding of what the employees want and need.

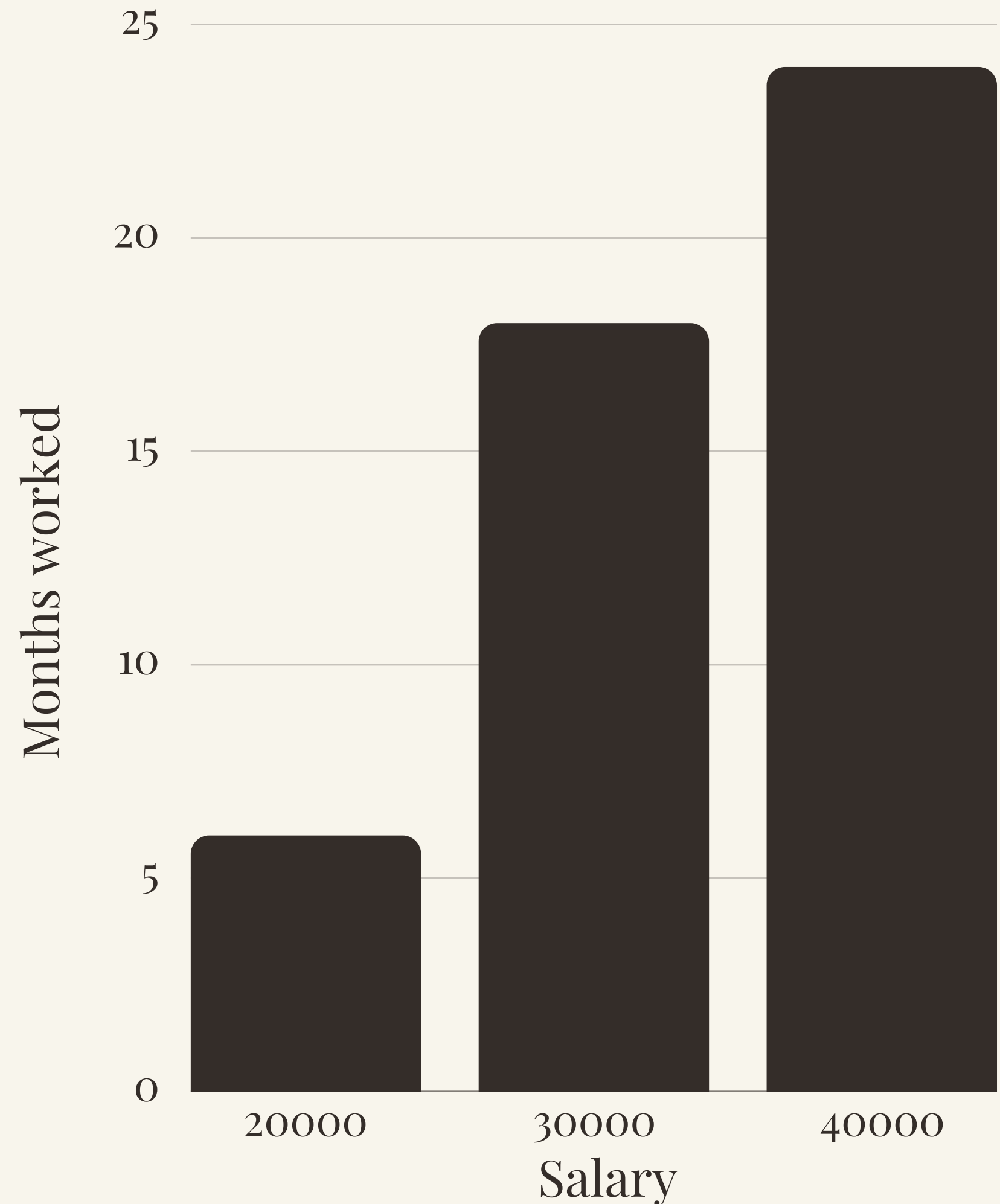
Focus Groups

We also conducted 3 focus groups filled with potential, current, and previous employees to determine the factors that draw new employees in, if they are currently happy with the company, and why they may have left. This will allow us to gage a full scope of all of our employees.

Projected Employee Retention in 2024

Pay vs Retention of Employee

- The data shown to the right shows the time the average employee making each of the salaries listed is retained.
- We see a massive increase from 20000 to 30000 which allows our employees to go over the national poverty line. Meaning they can afford to work full time
- The jump from 30000 to 40000 is much less and that must be taken into consideration when looking at the pay that we offer to employees



Findings



Key Findings from the Survey:

1. Competitive Compensation and Benefits:

Employees highly value fair pay and comprehensive benefits, emphasizing the importance of recognizing and rewarding their contributions.

2. Career Growth Opportunities:

Employees seek clear paths for career advancement within the company, indicating the importance of structured development programs and transparent promotion processes.

3. Supportive Work Culture:

A positive work culture that fosters open communication and community spirit emerged as crucial for employee engagement and satisfaction.

4. Flexible Work Arrangements:

There is a strong preference for flexible work arrangements, including remote options, reflecting the evolving work preferences of employees.

5. Regular Feedback and Recognition:

Consistent feedback and recognition for accomplishments play a significant role in boosting employee morale and job satisfaction.

6. Training and Development:

Employees appreciate organizations that invest in their growth, emphasizing the need for comprehensive training and development programs.

7. Strong Leadership and Communication:

Effective communication from leadership and approachable management are key factors contributing to a positive work environment.

8. Work-Life Balance:

The importance of work-life balance initiatives, such as flexible scheduling and time-off options, is evident in employee preferences.

9. Meaningful Work Alignment:

Employees seek meaningful work aligned with the company's values, emphasizing the importance of a shared mission.

10. Employee Wellness Programs:

Mental and physical health initiatives are valued, indicating a strong desire for employee wellness programs within the organization.

These findings provide valuable insights for Inklings to tailor retention strategies, ensuring a workplace that aligns with employee preferences and fosters a positive and engaging environment.

Conclusions



Inklings can translate the nuanced survey findings into concrete actions that will fortify its position as a community-centric workplace. The emphasis on fair compensation warrants a meticulous review of the existing pay structures, ensuring they align with industry standards and adequately recognize employees' contributions.

The quest for career growth signals an opportunity for Inklings to institute mentorship programs, training sessions, and transparent promotion processes, nurturing an environment where employees can envision a long-term trajectory within the company. To meet the growing demand for flexible work arrangements, Inklings can establish clear policies that accommodate remote work, enabling employees to strike a harmonious balance between their professional and personal lives.

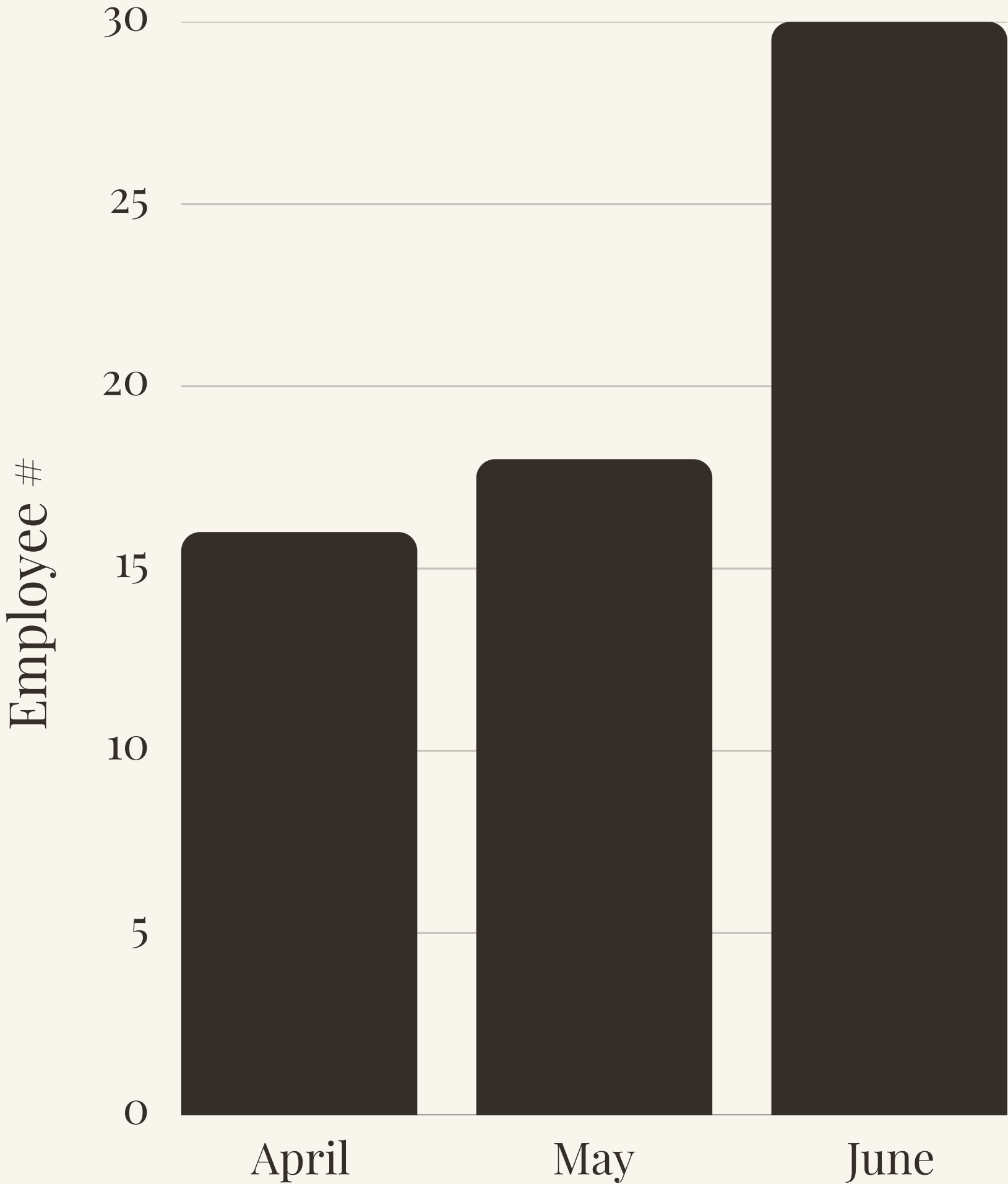
Furthermore, the call for comprehensive training and development programs presents a chance for Inklings to invest in ongoing learning initiatives, workshops, and skill-building activities that resonate with the diverse interests of its workforce.

Strengthening leadership communication involves not just clear directives but also creating avenues for open dialogue, perhaps through regular town hall meetings or feedback sessions. The emphasis on meaningful work aligned with company values necessitates a reiteration and reinforcement of the cafe's mission, ensuring that every employee sees their role as an integral part of a collective purpose.

The introduction or expansion of wellness programs presents an opportunity for Inklings to champion a holistic approach to employee well-being. This could involve partnerships with fitness providers, mental health resources, or even on-site wellness activities. In applying these insights in real-life scenarios, Inklings can not only enhance its workplace but also emerge as an employer of choice, attracting and retaining a dedicated workforce invested in the cafe's success and shared values.

Employee Retention Survey

- The graph to the right represents the amount of employees that are on salary part-time or full-time
- We see a steady employee count of around 16-18 concurrent employees throughout the late spring months
- As school gets out more applicants look for jobs and thus our employee count goes up
- Though we beleive in an equal and fair oppurtunity for everyone having almost double the employees for only 2 months isnt profitable thus we should severely limit the amount of employees hired this summer.



Strategic Plan



A. Objectives

The strategic plan for Inklings is a multifaceted approach aimed at elevating the overall customer experience by transforming the cafe into a haven that seamlessly blends productivity and relaxation. At the core of this initiative is the commitment to curate a diverse menu of high-quality coffee, ensuring that every sip is a delightful experience for patrons. This involves not only offering a variety of coffee blends but also considering specialty brews, unique flavors, and perhaps introducing seasonal selections to keep the menu dynamic and engaging.

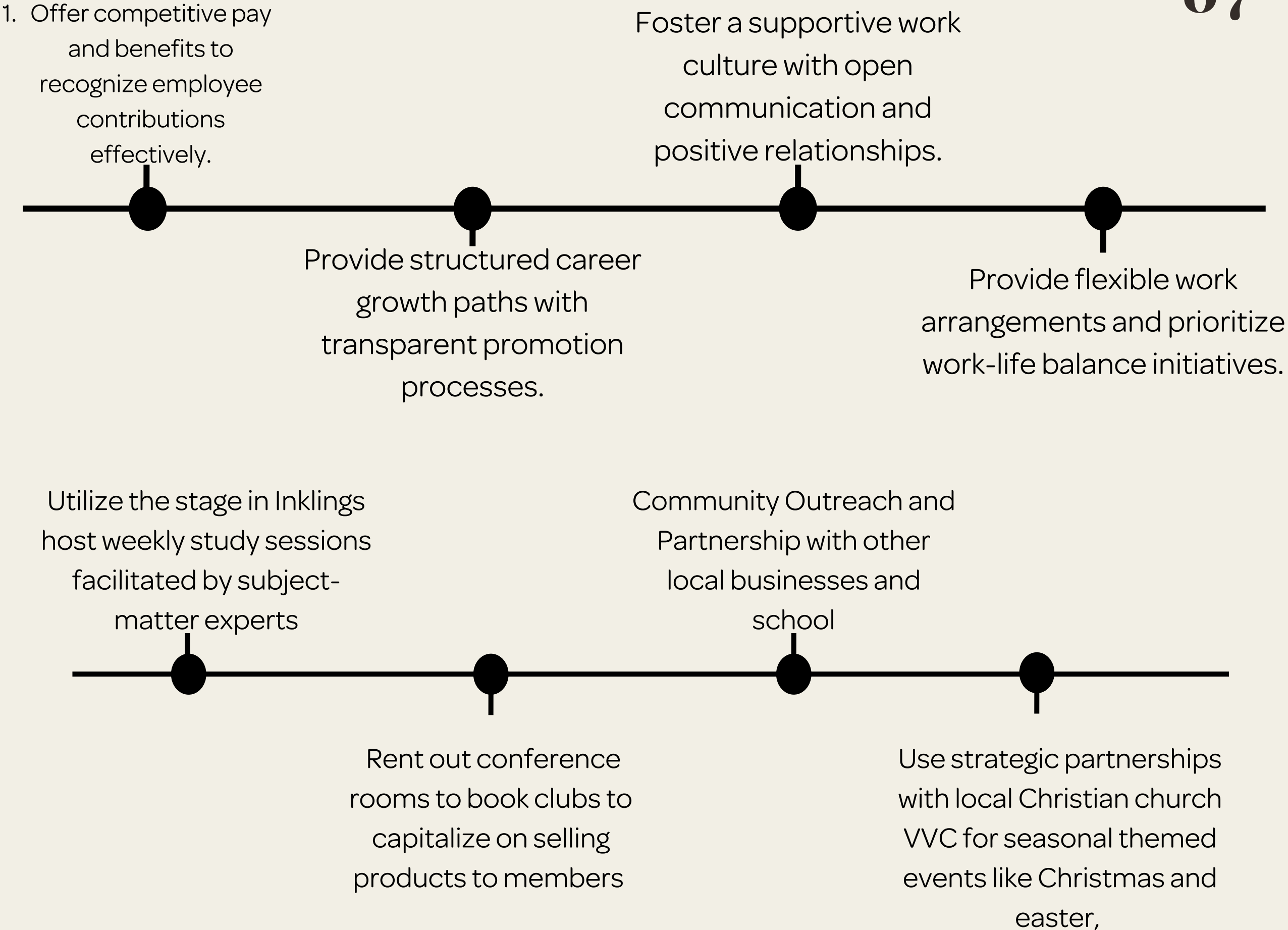
In tandem with refining the coffee offerings, the strategic plan places a strong emphasis on implementing a comprehensive marketing strategy. This strategy is designed not only to attract new customers but also to foster a stronger connection with the existing customer base.

Leveraging both traditional and digital platforms, Inklings aims to tell its unique story, emphasizing the warmth of its wooden interior, the quality of its ingredients, and the sense of community that defines the cafe. Social media campaigns, loyalty programs, and collaborations with local influencers or businesses can be integral components of this marketing strategy.

Moreover, the strategic plan integrates sustainable and community-oriented practices, aligning with the evolving values of customers. This may involve sourcing coffee beans from ethical and environmentally conscious suppliers, minimizing single-use plastics, and actively engaging with the local community through events or partnerships. By incorporating sustainable practices, Inklings not only contributes to environmental well-being but also resonates with a growing customer segment that values businesses with a social conscience.

In essence, this strategic plan positions Inklings as more than just a coffee shop; it envisions the cafe as a destination where patrons can not only savor exceptional coffee but also immerse themselves in a welcoming atmosphere that encourages both productivity and relaxation. By integrating a diverse menu, a robust marketing strategy, and a commitment to sustainability and community, Inklings aims to create a distinctive and enriching experience for its customers.

Strategic Plan (B)



Strategic Plan Continued...



C. Proposed metrics or key performance indicators to measure plan effectiveness:

1.-Customer Footfall:

- Measure the number of customers visiting the cafe over specific periods (daily, weekly, **monthly**).
- **Analyze footfall trends to identify peak hours and optimize staffing accordingly.**

2. Sales Revenue:

- Track overall revenue generated by the cafe on a daily, weekly, and monthly basis.
- Monitor the sales performance of specific offerings (e.g., coffee, snacks, merchandise).

3. Customer Retention Rate:

- Calculate the percentage of repeat customers over a defined period.
- Implement loyalty programs or customer feedback initiatives to enhance retention.

4. Event Participation:

- Measure attendance at themed nights, study sessions, open mic nights, and other events.
- Evaluate the success of events by gathering feedback and assessing the impact on footfall and revenue.

5. Social Media Engagement:

- Monitor social media metrics such as likes, shares, comments, and follower growth.
- Track the effectiveness of promotional campaigns and community engagement efforts.

6. Online Reviews and Ratings:

- Monitor online review platforms for customer reviews and ratings.
- Address negative feedback promptly and use positive reviews as testimonials for marketing.

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